What actually went right last week

The 5 stories readers chose, week of 5 October

Zoom out: In 1977, just 16 countries had abolished the death penalty. Today 113 have abolished it for all crimes. (Amnesty International)

Verified sources · published daily

10,000

Retired teacher Jim Crouch has grown and given away 10,000 oak seedlings across Southern California, opening a sixth nursery to help replant fire-scarred Altadena.

What it proves: The new La Canada High School nursery will supply oak seedlings directly to Altadena residents rebuilding after the Eaton fire.

89

Solar, wind and battery storage added 89 gigawatts of US capacity over the past 18 months, with utility solar up 33 percent and coal capacity down 2.4 percent.

What it proves: Renewable capacity can keep expanding at scale even against active federal policy working against it.

£72,000

Ahmed and Rifat Ali's home, condemned after they lost £72,000 to an unsafe extension, was rebuilt by more than 150 tradespeople and volunteers on BBC's DIY SOS, with cameras, visual fire and doorbell alerts and color changing lights built in for their deaf family.

Alastair Cass stepped outside after Arsenal lost 3-0 and heard a woman's cries from a valley near his Devon home, finding Sallie trapped chest-deep in mud for four hours and getting her help.

What it proves: One person noticing a faint sound and refusing to ignore it can locate someone no search team yet knew to look for.

90

Three community members and four Champaign, Illinois police officers were honored for pulling a 90-year-old woman from her flooding car in a retention pond, and she attended the ceremony to thank them.

What it proves: Neighbors and officers acting together within minutes can pull a flood victim from a submerged car before it is too late.

All five stories are linked in the post text above.

“It's the little things citizens do. That's what will make the difference.”

Wangari Maathai

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